

PSYC 1111-01 Week 5 Lesson Summary

Stress and Pain: Understanding and Management

Overview

This week focused on understanding stress and pain as health concerns, exploring psychological theories that explain these experiences, and learning effective management approaches.

Key Learning Objectives

- Understand how stress and pain relate to illness development
 - Explore theoretical frameworks for interpreting stress and pain experiences
 - Identify factors that affect how people experience stress and pain
 - Learn various approaches for managing stress and pain
 - Apply coping strategies during challenging circumstances
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Main Topics Covered

1. Understanding Pain as a Health Issue

Chronic Pain Definition:

- Pain lasting beyond 3 months
- Affects physical functioning, mental health, and quality of life
- Creates significant healthcare costs and productivity loss

Why Pain Matters:

- Impacts millions globally
- Affects daily activities, work, and relationships
- Requires comprehensive treatment beyond just medication

2. The Gate Control Theory of Pain

Key Concept: Pain signals must pass through a "gate" in the spinal cord before reaching the brain. This gate can be opened or closed by various factors.

How It Works:

- **Large nerve fibers** carry non-painful sensations (touch, pressure)
- **Small nerve fibers** carry pain signals

- When large fibers are activated, they help **close the gate** and reduce pain
- The **brain** can also influence the gate through psychological factors

Practical Applications:

- Rubbing or applying pressure to an injury provides relief
- Heat/cold therapy activates large fibers
- Psychological factors (attention, emotion, expectations) can open or close the gate
- TENS units stimulate large fibers to reduce pain signals

3. Factors Affecting Pain Experience

Biological Factors:

- Type and location of injury
- Individual pain sensitivity differences
- Previous pain experiences

Psychological Factors:

- Emotions (anxiety and depression intensify pain)
- Mood and attention
- Past trauma increases pain sensitivity
- Expectations about pain

Social and Cultural Factors:

- Cultural attitudes toward pain expression
- Social support vs. isolation
- Environmental stress levels
- Access to treatment

4. Coping with Stress During COVID-19

Four Types of Coping Strategies:

1. Problem-Focused Coping

- Taking direct action to solve problems
- Examples: Creating schedules, seeking information, organizing routines
- Best when situation is controllable

2. Emotion-Focused Coping

- Managing emotional response to stress
- Examples: Meditation, deep breathing, journaling

- Best when situation is uncontrollable

3. Approach Coping

- Actively confronting stressors
- Examples: Seeking social support, gathering information
- Generally more effective long-term

4. Avoidance Coping

- Temporarily escaping from stressors
- Examples: Distraction, limiting news consumption
- Helpful short-term, problematic long-term

5. Building Resilience

Two Key Approaches:

1. Develop a Growth Mindset

- View challenges as learning opportunities
- Encourages adaptability and perseverance
- Helps reframe difficulties positively

2. Implement Stress Management Programs

- Teach emotion regulation skills
- Include mindfulness and relaxation techniques
- Personalize to individual needs
- Significantly improve mental health during crises

Pain Management Approaches

Cognitive-Behavioral Therapy (CBT)

- Identify and change thoughts/behaviors that worsen pain
- Challenge catastrophic thinking
- Develop healthier coping patterns

Physical Approaches

- Structured exercise programs (adapted to abilities)
- Strengthens muscles and improves flexibility
- Releases natural pain-relieving endorphins
- Pacing activities to prevent flare-ups

Relaxation Techniques

- Progressive muscle relaxation
- Deep breathing exercises
- Reduce muscle tension and stress

Mindfulness Meditation

- Observe pain without judgment
- Reduces emotional distress associated with pain
- Improves pain tolerance

Social Support

- Connect with others facing similar challenges
- Reduces isolation
- Provides practical coping strategies
- Emotional validation

Medical Coordination

- Appropriate medication use
 - Emphasis on non-pharmacological approaches
 - Gives patients active control over pain management
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Key Takeaways

1. **Pain is complex** - influenced by biological, psychological, and social factors
 2. **Gate Control Theory** shows pain can be modified through various interventions
 3. **Multiple coping strategies** are more effective than relying on one approach
 4. **Stress management requires flexibility** - adapt strategies to the situation
 5. **Building resilience** helps people face future challenges more effectively
 6. **Comprehensive treatment** addresses physical, emotional, and social aspects of pain
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Required Readings Summary

Ogden (2019) - Chapter 5:

- In-depth exploration of stress and pain
- Theoretical concepts and frameworks
- Role of psychological factors in management

Stretanski et al. (2024) - Psychological Interventions:

- Overview of chronic pain
- Role of psychological factors
- Effectiveness of various approaches

Zisopoulou & Varvogli (2023):

- Stress management methods
- Types of stress
- Evidence-based interventions

Application to Real Life

This week's content directly applies to:

- Managing chronic conditions (arthritis, cancer pain)
- Developing personal stress management strategies
- Understanding the mind-body connection in health
- Creating community health programs
- Supporting others during difficult times
- Building personal resilience for future challenges

Remember: Effective pain and stress management requires addressing biological, psychological, and social factors together.